

BUSTARDS

Bustards are medium to very large ground-living birds (including some of the heaviest flying birds) with long, stout legs but a short bill.

Birds in this order, the Otidiformes, have a steady, long-striding walk and pick insects, reptiles, small mammals, and vegetable matter from the ground

in semi-deserts, open grasslands, and crops. In flight, they show large white areas on their long, broad wings. Larger species are powerful, steady fliers, while smaller ones have rapid wingbeats, looking more like small wildfowl or gamebirds with square-tipped wings. Social birds, they form flocks where numbers remain sufficiently high.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	OTIDIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	26

KORI BUSTARD

Ardeotis kori
F: Otidae

Among the heaviest flying birds, weighing up to 19 kg (42 lb), this bustard occurs across eastern and southern Africa. It feeds on small vertebrates, carrion, and seeds.



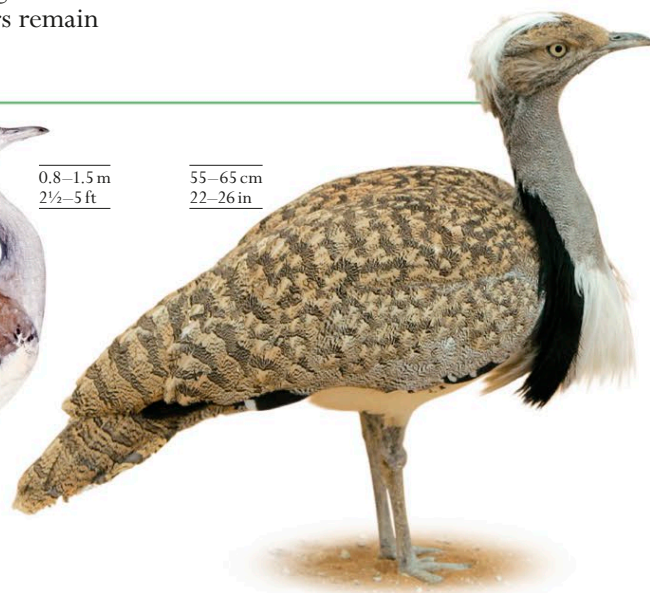
AUSTRALIAN BUSTARD

Ardeotis australis
F: Otidae

This bustard inhabits grasslands and open woodland of Australia and southern New Guinea. Males have a throat sac, which they inflate when displaying.



55–65 cm
22–26 in



HOUBARA BUSTARD

Chlamydotis undulata
F: Otidae

A native of arid country, this bird is found in open plains and barren desert areas of N. Africa and the Canary Islands.

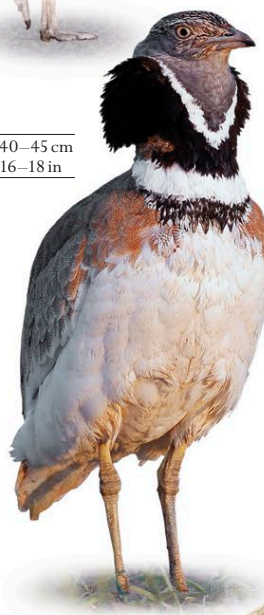
GREAT BUSTARD

Otis tarda
F: Otidae

Male bustards are bigger than females, especially so in this species of the Eurasian steppes. Adult birds take six years to mature and develop plumes.



40–45 cm
16–18 in



LITTLE BUSTARD

Tetrax tetrax
F: Otidae

This diminutive bustard breeds in open country across Eurasia and migrates southwards in winter. In flight, it resembles a shelduck.



RED-CRESTED BUSTARD

Lophotis ruficrista
F: Otidae

Like other bustards, this southern African species has a spectacular courtship display. Males perform tumbling aerial flights, and pairs call in duet.